

pro bono or work-based skills outside the company. Encouraging the latter type of volunteering was Caroline's priority. Because of its talent and values, HP's combined workforce has the potential to have a monumental positive impact. A designer could help a nonprofit with a new website design. A team of engineers could wire a school for Internet access.

Caroline's project is just beginning, and most employees do not know that this volunteering policy exists, and only a tiny fraction take advantage of it. Most of the volunteering has been of the low-impact variety, involving manual labor, even when the volunteers were highly trained experts. Barlerin's vision is to take the hundreds of thousands of employees in the company and transform them into a force for social good.

This is the kind of corporate initiative undertaken every day at companies around the world. It doesn't look like a startup by the conventional definition or what we see in the movies. On the surface it seems to be suited to traditional management and planning. However, I hope the discussion in [Chapter 2](#) has prompted you to be a little suspicious. Here's how we might analyze this project using the Lean Startup framework.

Caroline's project faces extreme uncertainty: there had never been a volunteer campaign of this magnitude at HP before. How confident should she be that she knows the real reasons people aren't volunteering? Most important, how much does she really know about how to change the behavior of hundreds of thousand people in more than 170 countries? Barlerin's goal is to inspire her colleagues to make the world a better place. Looked at that way, her plan seems full of untested assumptions—and a lot of vision.

In accordance with traditional management practices, Barlerin is spending time planning, getting buy-in from various departments and other managers, and preparing a road map of initiatives for the first eighteen months of her project. She also has a strong accountability framework with metrics for the impact her project should have on the company over the next four years. Like many entrepreneurs, she has a business plan that lays out her intentions nicely. Yet despite all that work, she is—so far—creating one-off